

v6 — adds the corponation-as-systemic-villain thread to v5's cleaned register. Every wound, every cost, every gap in this chapter traces back to corponation machinations upstream. The narrator is quietly furious about it. Never preached, always inside the sentences. Carrion Logistics LLC, NeoCortex/Atlas, Helix, Hydraulic Solutions, Arcturus — the boot has a brand on its heel.

**Held from v5: no sword mythology, no
parenthetical asides, all humor woven in.**

Bearing Teeth

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I — Teeth

The freight elevator was the only thing in the building that worked, and it worked because Carrion Logistics LLC needed it to.

The resident elevator had been there once. There was a shaft and there were doors on every floor and a piece of paper taped to one of them said OUT OF SERVICE in three languages, none of them recent. The corporation that had installed it filed bankruptcy in 2207, got bought by a corporation that got bought by Carrion Logistics LLC, the body-pickup federation, which did not maintain the resident elevator because the residents did not generate revenue but did maintain the freight elevator because the freight elevator moved the dead. In the Gray Zone this counted as integrated service.

Kyle rode the freight up. The cage was steel grating with a fine carpet of pulverized concrete on the floor — somebody had moved a refrigerator earlier, or somebody had moved a man, or somebody had moved both and the man had complained less. The ceiling LED had been the wrong color since 2218 and bathed everything in the institutional green of a hospital cafeteria at three in the morning. The cage went up at the speed the cage had decided on without consulting anybody, and without consulting Kyle either, which made the elevator no different from anyone else who lived in the building.

The airshaft brought the building's news up the side of the cage like a wet radio. Camphor from the second floor — somebody's grandmother, joints, a salve that had been working for years on a pain that had outworked it because the corporation insurance product the family had bought in 2218 did not cover the surgery the joints needed. Burnt rice from the fifth — Mr. Yu, eighty-three, refused a timer because his mother had not used one, and his rice had been burnt every Thursday since 2189, a tradition to him and an indictment to his neighbors. And tonight, from somewhere between four and seven, the smell of Chen Wei-Lin's deep fryer: pork bone, scallion, oil that had not been changed since the lunar new year because the oil was the seasoning and because the cooking-oil futures market the corporations had cornered in 2222 had priced new oil out of her ledger.

The work was always already there before you got to it. The smell was the contract. Kyle stepped off on the eighth floor and the building knew his answer before he did.

Unit 802 was at the end of the hall behind a door that had been painted four times at four attempts at the color white. Mrs. Chen answered before the second knock.

"Come in, Mr. Corbin."

She had been working on his name through the duration of the phone call and had landed on *Mr. Corbin*, which was correct in the way calling a man by his middle name with *Mr.* in front was correct. He let it go. The Atlas array catalogued her face whether he wanted it to or not — 83% Cantonese, 11% Hakka, scar on the left thumb-base from a slip with a cleaver at nine or ten in a kitchen with poor task lighting — and he set the read aside the way he had been setting it aside since nineteen, when a Vietnamese-Senegalese stevedore in a bar had explained at some length the social cost of saying that kind of count out loud, an explanation that had taken Kyle's right eyebrow some time to recover from. The read was not Kyle's. The read had been installed in him at fifteen by people who had needed soldiers who could identify recruits by skull geometry across a Korean DMZ and had funded the work through a NeoCortex black-budget line that did not, on paper, exist.

The apartment was three rooms and a curtain. A folding chair, a low table, a television last turned on the year before last and now serving as the surface where the family kept clementines, envelopes, and a small carved wooden frog with a chip out of its left back leg. He suspected the daughter.

The husband was in the corner. A wicker chair, two breaks in the cane, both wrapped in electrical tape. He sat with his weight off the broken places like a man who had been sitting like that for twenty-nine days and had stopped expecting the rest of the chair back. His jaw was wired with the four-point titanium a Gray Zone field clinic put in when there was no budget for plates and was not going to be. The clinic was a Carrion Logistics LLC subsidiary running an Arcturus subcontract on a unit-rate margin that priced plates at

thirty percent over the field-clinic budget cap, which meant the field clinic did not buy plates and the patient did not get them. The wire had been pulled tight before the swelling went down, which the patient had discovered on day three when the swelling went down and the wire stayed tight — the kind of detail the Carrion subcontract did not have an indemnity column for. Liu breathed through his nose, slow and even, the way a man breathed who had been breathing through his nose since March.

"My husband's name is Liu," Mrs. Chen said. She offered the introduction as if it might matter. It did. "He was a cook. He was a very good cook."

Liu blinked once at Kyle. The blink was the bow. Kyle returned it, smaller, in the way men returned bows in rooms where speech was not an even option for everybody present.

The light in the room was the color of weak tea. The fixture had been wired into the airshaft duct fifteen years ago by a tenant who had not been an electrician but had been confident, and the bulb the tenant had installed was a 2210 closeout from a Wicker hardware store that had been a Pinnacle Civil property until Pinnacle Civil collapsed in 2217 after its CEO had been indicted for routing the firm's tax obligations through a shell he had also been the CEO of. The closeout bulb was a Pinnacle Civil house brand. There were forty-six of them left in the world. Chen Wei-Lin had bought twelve in 2218 and was on her seventh, which meant the light in this apartment would last her another twenty-four years and was therefore on a schedule longer than the leases of any of the corporations she would buy lightbulbs from again. The window across the room looked at the tower opposite, close enough to read the laundry on its eighth-floor balcony — a family of three or four, an aspirational interest in linen — and behind the laundry the canyon was full of rain. Warm rain at this tier. The upper-tier rain came from cloud and was cold; the lower-tier rain had been through six tiers of Arcturus HVAC exhaust on the way down and was warm by the time it got down here, which the people on the eighth floor had been hearing on their metal awning four floors below for thirty-seven years and had stopped registering as a sound. In another window two buildings over a man was arguing with a ride-share AI about a routing question. Kyle could not hear him. The argument was visible in the shoulders, doing the thing

shoulders did when they had been losing a conversation for four to six minutes to a corporation product that was contractually permitted to be wrong and contractually protected from being held to it. He wished the man well.

"The men who came," Mrs. Chen said.

"Yes."

"There were six. The one I want is named Tien." She gestured with one hand at her husband, small and economical, the gesture of a woman who did not want to enlarge the wound by pointing at it. "He hit my husband three times with the back of a wrench. The first on the side of the head. The second on the jaw. The third on the jaw also. After the third he was satisfied."

"Why."

"The license."

She said it as if she had been certain he would understand the word in the specific sense it was used in this building on this floor. He did. The stall license was three thousand Φ a year, issued through Carrion Logistics LLC, billed in twelve installments unless you missed one, in which case billed in one installment plus interest plus a visit from a man named Tien, the latter of which the invoice itemized as *Compliance Verification* and which Carrion Logistics LLC's investor materials counted under *enforcement-margin revenue*, a line item the 2225 annual report had cited as growing thirty-one percent year over year and had cited as evidence of the federation's continuing operational health. The Chens' jaw was operational health.

"You were short this month."

"Eight hundred."

"Why."

"The cold snap. We ran the fryer harder. The gas bill cleared on the third. The eight hundred would have been in the box on the third. Tien came on the second."

"On purpose."

"On purpose."

The cold snap had been the result of the corporation atmospheric processors three sectors east running a maintenance window in March they had budgeted for February, which Arcturus had documented in a press release nobody read and which had cost the Chens, by Kyle's estimate, sixteen hundred Φ in additional fryer gas they had not budgeted for. The corporation that had issued the press release was the corporation whose subsidiary had issued the stall license whose enforcement had wired Liu's jaw. The trail did not loop. The trail terminated.

A figure moved behind the curtain into the second room. The breathing pattern had been there since the hallway. Twelve, maybe thirteen. The curtain shifted now and a face appeared at it. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was not one a child should be having to wear.

She did not come in. She did not retreat. She watched.

Kyle did not look at her directly. Looking at her would have put her in the conversation, and the conversation was not for her. Mrs. Chen had not turned. Mrs. Chen knew her daughter was there. Mrs. Chen had decided, possibly tonight, possibly six years ago, that *daughter sees what daughter sees* was a discipline of a kind she could not protect against and would not try to.

The damp credits came out of Mrs. Chen's apron in a thin stack banded with a pink hair-elastic. She pressed them into Kyle's palm with both hands. He felt the weight and ran the count: six hundred and forty Φ . Half the standing rate. Two of the chips were 2217-issue, the year the corporations had unified on a single Φ standard after a four-year currency war, which made them older than the daughter watching from behind the curtain and softer

than the new ones, the patina the chip developed after eight years in a working person's apron — pressed against fabric and fryer-warm and other people's damp credits — was a patina the corporations had not anticipated and had not been able to monetize.

"I do not have all of it, Mr. Corbin."

"It is enough."

"I do not have all of it because—"

"Mrs. Chen. It is enough."

She had the specific exhaustion of a woman who had practiced the sentence seven times and had now been told the sentence was not required. The relief did not arrive in her face. It arrived in her hands; they stopped trembling at the second knuckle of the index first, the thumbs after, the rest on a half-second delay, the way circulation came back to a limb that had been folded under itself in sleep.

Two stories up, someone began playing a Cantonese pop song from 2218 — a hit then, not a hit now, but the song the building had played at funerals for the four years it had been a hit because the algorithm a corporation streaming service had served it to the building had been calibrated to serve the song to bereavements as cheaply as possible. Whether Unit 1004 had chosen it on purpose or the algorithm had served it on some confluence of recent searches the algorithm did not have permission to disclose, the effect was the same. The song was not, on this occasion, for Liu Chen. Liu Chen was still alive. The song was, in a manner of speaking, on retainer.

"You will be careful, Mr. Corbin."

"I will be efficient."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

She bowed. He bowed. The bows were the contract. She told him the rest — the address at the bottom of the eastern strut, the side door nobody locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the side door, the front door nobody locked because nobody was foolish enough to walk in the front, the schedule of when Tien drank and slept and did the thing he did instead of work. Sable had given Kyle the same information through the cracked terminal the previous Tuesday. He had known where Tien would be before he had climbed the stairs. He had come anyway, because Mrs. Chen needed to give him the address. The address was the gift she had to deliver in order to be the person who delivered it.

He left through the door he had come in. On the ride down a phrase arrived in his head — *the bill is the bill, the boy is the bill* — in a diction that was not his and a register a dead test subject from the NeoCortex Atlas program had used as their own, and Kyle said *no* aloud to the empty cage and the channel went quiet. The boy from the Grind held. He always did. Eventually. The hardware in his skull belonged, on the paper that mattered to the people who had installed it, to NeoCortex. Kyle had stopped reading that paper at seventeen. The hardware had not stopped reading him.

The bike was where he had left it, two blocks east under a tier-six awning that did most of the work of keeping it dry. Matte black, unbranded, three plates magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. He swapped to the one issued to a Carrion Logistics LLC subcontractor in 2206 that had never been cancelled — the Gray Zone surveillance grid was a forty-year-old corporation cast-off that let a Carrion plate go anywhere a Carrion plate had ever been, and Carrion plates had been most places, because Carrion had won the body-pickup contract in 2186 and had refused to share it for forty years. The bike rolled clean. He had spent two hours that afternoon repairing a tensioner he could have replaced for forty Φ . Forty Φ was two of Mrs. Chen's bowls. The math came out the way the math came out.

He rode south. Twenty-two minutes of switchbacks down freight ramps the corporations had stopped maintaining around the second tier rezoning, when the corporations had withdrawn from the residential market to focus on what their annual reports called *higher-margin verticals*, which was the

corporation polite term for *anything that was not actually serving people who needed it*. Each ramp dropped him about eight stories. By the third the architecture had stopped pretending to be architecture and had become what it actually was, which was welded industrial grief. By the fifth, the rain was warmer. The sky where he could see it was the bruise the GLMZ sky was at this hour — orange under, indigo over, the Pulse-corridor light pollution running east-west across the middle like a healing scar. A VTOL crossed the gap between two towers a long way overhead, running lights amber, climbing toward the corporation roof-traffic stratum. Some board director was late to dinner. Forty stories below the board director, in a stairwell that smelled like ammonia, a child whose grandmother had died because the building's stair lighting did not work was learning to read the dark. The stair lighting had not worked since 2219, when an Arcturus property-management subsidiary had reclassified stairwells as common-area rather than habitable-area to dodge the lighting code. The reclassification had been challenged in 2221 by a tenants' group and had been upheld in 2223 by a court whose judges had been confirmed by a senator whose campaign Arcturus had funded. The grandmother had been ninety-one. These two facts were the city. Kyle did not file the running lights. He had stopped filing the running lights in his twenties.

A second VTOL crossed the same gap the other way, going the wrong way for an Arcturus board-floor late-shift commute, which suggested either the first VTOL's wife meeting it halfway or the first VTOL's tax attorney, who sometimes was. The bike was running clean. The chain was good.

The katana rode his right shoulder in a matte friction sheath — a hundred and two centimeters of carbon-edged steel forged on a Tuesday in 2199 by a man named Dae-jung Seo in the back room of a repair shop that had been a repair shop because Seo had thought *swordsmith* was too loud a word for what he did. Seo had survived eleven years inside Torii Security Group's chrome-augment program — a corporation military contract he had walked out of in 2197 with the augments that would eventually kill him and a clarity about who he would not work for again — and had given Kyle the blade along with the work that came with it on the same Tuesday. The blade had been a sword for eleven years now and was a sword still. Other things were said about it on the street. Kyle had stopped correcting the other

things. The people he had corrected had a way of dying mid-correction, and dying mid-correction did not adjust anyone's opinion of the sword. *Silence*, somebody had called it, and the name had stuck because the city named everything it wanted to talk about, including things it had been wrong about, including this one.

Kyle parked the bike a block out and walked.

The loading dock sat at the bottom of the eastern strut where the strut met the tier-zero substrate and the substrate was just concrete. The building was on the Arcturus property registry as *industrial — out of service — pending evaluation*, a designation Arcturus had been applying to buildings in this part of the Gray Zone since 2218, on the working theory that *pending evaluation* was cheaper than *vacant* in the corporation tax code and indistinguishable from *vacant* in actual use. Six bays. Two roller doors open. The light inside was the amber sodium of overheads installed before LED was a word, which made everything look like a polaroid in a kitchen drawer.

At the corner of the alley a man with a backpack was trying to sell stolen ramen to a stevedore who did not want stolen ramen. The stevedore had a sandwich in one hand and the conversational stamina of a man on his break, which was to say none. They were still working it out when Kyle walked past. Neither looked up. Neither would, later, remember they had been there. Kyle would, but Kyle remembered everything, which was a feature of the hardware and not of Kyle.

He came in through the front because surprise was free.

Six men. Card game on a crate. They were playing pai gow with hand-marked tiles because somebody had spilled something on the cards a week ago and nobody had replaced them. Tien was winning. Tien was always winning, because Tien beat the others when Tien lost, and the others had figured this out and had agreed, quietly, to let Tien win.

The two chrome-arm men leaned against a stack of dollies — Hydraulic Solutions ARM-9 series by the wrist articulation pattern. Hydraulic

Solutions was a Helix subsidiary that had been spun off in 2218 to limit Helix's liability on a class-action lawsuit a group of veterans had filed over hand-tremor incidents the ARM-7 had been causing, which Helix had settled in 2220 by paying the veterans an average of two thousand Φ each — less than the cost of removing the arms the veterans had been issued — and which had freed Helix to put the ARM-9 on the market in 2221 with a redesigned elbow flexor that had been recalled in 2222 for a tendency to lock at full extension under high-amperage stress. Neither of the men on the dock had taken Hydraulic Solutions up on the recall, because the recall required a certified clinic, which required identification documents the men did not possess, which would have required them to acquire identification documents, which would have required Carrion Logistics LLC, which they had preferred not. The recall, in their specific case, was still alive.

Of the four seated, one had subdermal thoracic plating visible as faint geometric ridges along the collar — low-end clinic, fast install, no aftercare, the kind of work the Carrion-tier subcontractors had been doing since 2222 when the corporation regulators had stopped inspecting them. One had chrome knuckles and a face the array put at nineteen, augmentation strictly cosmetic and very fresh, financed by a Hydraulic Solutions consumer-credit subsidiary at an interest rate that, if he survived the year, was going to cost him approximately three times the install price by the time he had paid the arm off. One had no visible work, which meant whatever he had was internal, which meant expensive, which meant he had made decisions. The last had a face rebuilt cheap and tight on the left side, the skin pulled the wrong way over the lower mandible, the parts of his face having run out. Tien.

The laughter died at the tempo laughter always died when the math changed in a room. It died last in the chrome-knuckle kid, who was nineteen and had not yet learned to read tempo.

The boss set his tiles face down.

"You lost, friend?"

"Looking for Tien."

The boss looked at Tien. Tien looked at the boss. The boss looked back at Kyle. He had decided to make this take one more sentence than it strictly needed to, which was the decision of a man who had not yet been told the math had finished resolving.

"Tien is occupied."

"He won't be."

The boss did the head-tilt men did when they wanted the room to know something interesting was happening. The chrome-knuckle kid's hand began to move toward his waistband, telegraphed at the shoulder a full half-second before the hand committed. The two chrome-arm men shifted their weight a quarter inch each, hydraulic shoulders waking the actuator buses Helix had advertised in 2221 as *combat-quiet* and which were not, in fact, combat-quiet, but which a Helix marketing decision had decided to call combat-quiet regardless. The subdermal-plated man set his tiles down. Tien sat very still and watched, which was Tien's correct response — Tien had made it to thirty-four in this work by knowing exactly which fights were his and exactly which fights were not.

Kyle's chest warmed. The array. A coal blown to life behind the sternum, thirty-two thousand electrodes on a NeoCortex Atlas-program research grade Kyle had not consented to as the boy from the Grind and had inherited as the man who walked out of the facility in 2208 with what the program had put in him and no documentation it had been put. The room rendered in the second channel — six bodies, six firing solutions, the kid's forearm flexor tightening, the saya inside the boss's coat visible in the way the fabric draped. The boss was carrying a katana inside his coat at a card game on a Tuesday night. That was a choice a man made when a man was expecting somebody.

The boss had been expecting Kyle. Somebody had paid him to be here tonight with a sword, prepared. Somebody had wanted, specifically, to see what a Korean blade did against the man people had been telling stories about for two years. The somebody was, by the shape of the funding pattern Kyle had been seeing across his pipeline lately, a corporation with research interests in the Atlas-program continuation work and a budget line for live-

fire performance benchmarking against unauthorized field specimens. *Unauthorized field specimens* was the corporation polite term for *the boy who walked out*. Kyle filed the somebody. He would think about it later.

"Kyle from down the street."

The boss smiled.

Chorus came out of the holster in Kyle's left hand.

Crack — crack-crack-crack.

Four shots in three seconds. Buckshot at the chrome-knuckle kid's right knee — the joint separated rather than bent, and he went down sideways with the sound a body made when screaming required more composure than the body had. Slug at the subdermal man's left knee — his fighting philosophy ended at his chest and the kneecap had not been consulted. Slug at the near chrome-arm man's right knee — hydraulics did not load-bear on the leg and the leg had been the leg. Slug at Tien's left knee, because Tien's face was the face Kyle wanted on the floor at an angle that would loosen teeth.

The far chrome-arm man had started his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second, which was the correct response from a fighter with hydraulic reach and a head start on the geometry. Kyle stepped under the arc — the arm passed where his collarbone had been — and brought the katana up. Right hand over the right shoulder. The blade cleared the saya in one continuous motion. He put the edge into the shoulder seam where chrome met flesh — three and a half centimeters of unprotected actuator housing exposed at the cooling vent, a gap Helix had designed into the ARM-9 in 2221 because the cooling-vent redesign that would have closed the gap had been over budget — and the edge passed through the gap the way an edge passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. The arm finished its swing into empty air without its owner. The motor bus was severed at the shoulder; the rest of the man did what bodies did when load-bearing chrome stopped sending signals. Then the elbow flexor locked at full extension, because Helix's 2222 recall had not been performed, and the dead arm went stiff at his side like a man hailing a

cab. Helix's investor relations would have called this the unit operating outside specifications. Kyle was inclined to disagree.

Three seconds. Four shots. One sword cut. Five men down.

Tien made a noise face-down in the drainage channel that was not really a noise.

Kyle turned.

The boss had stood up. He had not drawn during the count. He had stood the way a man stood when he had watched his crew dismantle on schedule and had decided it was now his turn. The hand that went to his hip came back with a katana. The blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo, point neither high nor low, weight settling into a guard that had not been borrowed from any school Kyle could name. The man knew his work. Somebody had paid for the work, and the work had landed, and the work was now going to die on this floor for the benefit of the somebody who had paid for it, who would receive a report in two weeks describing how the work had performed against the unauthorized field specimen and would file the report against the budget line and would assign the next round of testing to the next Korean swordsman on the procurement list.

"Sloppy entrance," the boss said, evenly, like a teacher correcting homework. The Korean was inflected through the English in the careful way of someone who had paid for the English along with the swordwork.

Kyle did not answer. The answer was not in language.

They closed.

First exchange. The boss tested the line — a short cut at Kyle's right shoulder, no commitment, the kind of strike a swordsman used to read his opponent's reach. Kyle's blade rose. The steel met edge to flat at a shallow angle and rang a clean sustained note in the concrete. *Tang.* The boss read his information, stepped back, no expression. His weight stayed off the front foot.

Second exchange. Kyle pressed. Two-step advance, cut high right. The boss deflected rather than parried, sliding Kyle's flat past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative. He had been trained against blades that did things the corporations had been telling buyers about for thirty years and would not stop telling buyers about because the telling sold curriculum. None of what he had been told to expect was going to arrive, and he would not learn that in the time he had remaining.

Third exchange. The boss committed. Cut high left, fast, clean, no telegraph. Kyle's parry was a fraction late and the follow-through grazed his left forearm. Three inches of skin opened — vein not artery, would impair grip on the shotgun side in approximately ninety seconds. Blood came up immediately. The boss saw it and read it as the answer to the question he had been asking, which was *am I better than the man this is supposed to be*. He had decided he was. The corporation that had paid for his curriculum would have endorsed the decision. The corporation was wrong, and his curriculum was wrong, and the decision was the kind of decision a man made when his confidence in a thing he had been sold had outpaced his ability to verify it.

Fourth exchange. The thrust. Straight, committed, full extension. Kyle did not meet it at the edge or the flat. He met it at the seppa — the small collar between the tsuba and the blade — and the thrust locked there, blade to blade, no give. Kyle drove forward. He kept the lock. He let his edge ride along the flat of the boss's steel like a skate on ice, tracking from tip toward middle toward tsuba, and where the boss's blade met the boss's hand, the edge met the boss's right wrist.

Bone. Tendon. The radial and ulnar arteries. The median nerve. The carpal architecture that had held a sword for whatever number of years the boss had been training for this duel.

The boss's right hand and the boss's katana fell together to the corrugated steel.

Clang.

The boss looked at his wrist. He looked at his sword on the floor. He looked at Kyle.

"Oh," he said.

The brachial did most of the work. He bled out in nineteen seconds. Twenty-three seconds for the duel. Twenty-six on the dock floor end to end.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes. He had learned to use the window.

He sheathed the blade. A thin line of red near the kissaki; he wiped it against the boss's coat before the steel seated. Chorus went back into the holster. Four chambers spent, one slug still in the cylinder.

The boss's face, the array offered him on closing, was 71% Korean, 22% Han, 7% noise. The trail upstream of him ran through a Helix procurement officer in Seoul, through a Helix research budget the officer reported to, through an Atlas-program continuation directorate Helix subcontracted to, through a NeoCortex steering committee Atlas reported to, through three more committees, and out the top of a building in Geneva that Kyle had not been to and would not be invited to, where the people who had ordered the swordsman did not, individually, know they had ordered a swordsman, because the budget lines they signed off on did not specify swords. The lesson was now ambient on the floor of a loading dock in the Gray Zone at 0157 in the morning. The Geneva committee would not learn it. The Helix procurement officer would learn it in two weeks and would write down a finding and would file it against the budget line and would assign the next testing round. The next round was not Kyle's problem until it was.

Tien was crying. Not screaming. Crying. He had figured out by the third kneecap shot that he was not going to die tonight, and the prospect of *not dying tonight* in his current condition was now striking him as worse than the alternative.

Kyle moved through the bodies, methodical. He was looking for the third tooth.

He had two in his left hand already — two loose ones, recovered with a thumb and forefinger from the steel where Tien's face had landed. The third was still seated. He found Tien's mouth and, with the careful neutrality of a man pulling a nail out of a board, gripped the third tooth and turned. It came free with a sound that was not really a sound. Tien sobbed once, briefly, and stopped, because what he had been sobbing about was no longer at the top of the list.

Kyle stood up with the teeth in his hand.

He had decided what he was going to do with them on the ride down, twenty-two minutes ago, somewhere around the fifth switchback. The thinking had taken about a minute. The remaining twenty-one minutes of the ride had been spent confirming he had not missed an option. He had not missed an option. The option was correct, and it was the kind of correct that an old man named Hammurabi had been writing tablets about three and a half millennia before Kyle had been born, and the boy from the Grind had not been taught Hammurabi at the corporation public-education branch that had closed in 2208 when its funding had been redirected to a Carrion-affiliated charter school the boy from the Grind had not been eligible for, but the math of *what a family was owed* was not the kind of math a teacher had to teach.

Across the dock, behind the ventilation unit on the far wall, the breathing pattern Kyle had tracked since the threshold shifted. Twelve, maybe thirteen. The breathing had been there in Unit 802 too. She had come down. He did not know how she had done it. He did not need to know.

She had come to see.

Kyle walked to the ventilation unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall, blood-misted shape in the dock's bad amber — and waited. The breathing stopped. Then a slow movement. A face came around the corner of the unit. The jaw was her father's, before the wrench. The eyes were her mother's. The expression was a child's expression that had not been issued to a child before tonight.

Kyle crouched. He went down to her eye level the way he went down to a child's eye level whenever the situation gave him room to. Seo had said it once, in the room behind the repair shop, when Kyle was eighteen and a child had walked past the open door: *be at their height when you speak to them*. Kyle did not know whether Seo had originated the line or had quoted it. Seo had quoted a lot of people and had not always cited.

Kyle opened his hand.

The three teeth lay in his palm. Two intact. The third with a hairline fracture from where he had gripped it. The smell of blood was the smell of blood.

The girl looked at his hand. Then at his face. Then back at his hand.

"Present these to your father." His voice was even. He had practiced even for a long time. "I think he will appreciate the gesture."

She held out her hands. Cupped.

He poured the teeth into her cupped palms.

She did not drop them.

She shrieked. High, thin, a sound that bounced off every hard surface in the dock and came back changed. She did not drop them. Her fingers closed over them. She looked at her closed hands. She looked at him. And then, slowly, deliberately, with a gravity that was not in any culture Kyle could name but which her body seemed to know on its own, she bowed.

A full bow. From the waist. Held for two seconds. Her hands stayed cupped at her chest the entire time.

The bow of a child who had just been handed an inheritance she had not asked for and was not yet sure what was going to be expected of her in the carrying of it. The inheritance was not new. The inheritance was old. Three and a half millennia old. The corporations had not yet built a product that addressed it. They had built products around it. They had built products in spite of it. They had not built a product that disposed of it, because the kind

of person who would have bought such a product was not the kind of person who needed it, and the corporation actuaries had run the model in 2212 and had filed the finding under *non-addressable market*.

Then she was gone, swallowed by the dark beyond the door, her feet making no sound on the steel because she had been raised in a building where you learned, by five, not to make sound on steel.

Kyle stood for three seconds. The second channel, in a register that was not his, said *that one will outlive most of us*, and Kyle did not recognize the diction at all this time — three subjects deep, possibly four. He did not have the bio-battery to chase it. He let it pass.

He cleaned the blade. The tremor started in his right hand at the four-minute mark, moved to his left, became briefly bilateral — the array's invoice arriving, several thousand calories called in twenty-six seconds, the body presenting the bill. His stomach was a closed fist. He needed protein, carbohydrate, something hot in a bowl, something that required no decisions.

He walked back to the bike. The bike started on the first turn. He swapped the plate two blocks short of the Wicker boundary and continued north on a different fiction.

Part II — Standard Rate

Chen's stall was two blocks south of the freight tier and one alley off the main, and the warm orange of its hood lamp was visible through the rain from a block away the way a hearth was visible through the trees in a children's book Kyle had not read but had heard described.

He walked the bike the last block. The bike rolled easier at walking pace than it rode at speed because the front wheel was true and the bearings were clean and the chain was good and the repaired tensioner held. The math came out the way the math came out.

She was at the counter when he arrived. The apron was clean — a service apron, not the kitchen apron she had been wearing in the apartment, which had had bone broth fat on the front. The service apron did not deal with the stockpot, only with the bowls and the counter and the customers. The apron she had worn at home in front of her wired-jaw husband had been a third apron, and Kyle now retroactively confirmed its existence because Chen Wei-Lin would not have offered service in a kitchen apron and would not have sat with her husband in a service apron either.

The small scar at the base of her left thumb caught the lamp light. The daughter was somewhere he could not see. She had taken some route Kyle had not mapped from the dock back to here, faster than the bike, which meant she had either run through the airshafts or had a private courier route Carrion Logistics LLC had let her use without anyone asking. The daughter was a freight system unto herself. Kyle filed this for later.

She did not greet him. She set a bowl on the counter — pork bone broth, the fourteen-hour kind, simmering at the back of the stall in a Ming-mark thirty-quart stockpot from Foshan that had been in Chen Wei-Lin's family across two husbands, four children, three cities, and three planets, and had been continuously simmering for the better part of forty years across all three. The pot, like the freight elevator, was the only thing in the building that worked, and it worked because no corporation had bought it, no corporation had thought to buy it, no corporation had yet identified

continuous-simmer ancestral cookware as a vertical worth acquiring. The chili oil was already in the bowl, the way she would remember he liked it for the next four years. She ladled with three quick dips: once to skim, once to stir, once to draw. The third dip was the one she poured.

He sat. The stool was the right height for him. She had not adjusted it. He had not adjusted it. The geometry was simply what it was the first time.

He ate standing up everywhere else. At Mrs. Chen's, he sat. Not because she had offered the stool. Because the stool, having been offered, was offered, and the discipline of accepting what had been offered was the discipline he had begun the moment she brought the bowl.

He ate. The broth was hot. He ate the whole bowl and did not speak. She did not refill it. She did not move. When he set the chopsticks down she was still standing exactly where she had been. She was looking at him the way she had looked at the chips she had pressed into his hand six hours ago — she had more she wanted to give and no language for the giving, and she was now finding the language.

Cantonese first, low. *Mh̄gōi*. Two syllables doing the work of an entire ledger. Then, in the tongue she had chosen to run the stall in because she did not assume every customer spoke hers:

"Free. Always. For you. Forever."

Her hands were flat on the counter. Her scarred thumb was the closest thing to him on the wood. She had just offered him the only thing she owned.

Kyle reached into his coat and set a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate.

"I pay. Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time."

She did not pick up the chip. He did not pick up the bowl. The standoff lasted four seconds and was the most important four seconds of their relationship, and they both knew it without naming it.

She tried again, slower.

"You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing."

Kyle did not move the chip.

"If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays."

The four seconds became five.

Her hand closed over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth — not refusing the gift, accepting that the gift was the form the man in front of her needed the gift to take.

She bowed. A small bow. The bow of a vendor accepting a customer's price. The kind of bow she would give him every night, three hundred nights a year, for the next four years and longer. The corporation models of customer-vendor relationship did not have a category for the bow. The corporation models had categories for *transaction frequency* and *lifetime value* and *churn risk*. The bow was something the corporation models could not see, and what the corporation models could not see was, in this small specific way, the thing the corporations could not own, and the thing the corporations could not own was the thing Chen Wei-Lin and Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister were going to spend the next four years quietly accumulating between them at standard rate.

He stood. He bowed back, smaller still — the bow of a man who had just successfully refused a kindness larger than he could carry.

"Tomorrow. Same bowl. Same price."

"Same price."

The agreement was the contract. The contract was the bond.

He turned and walked the bike out of the stall's lamp circle. The rain had not stopped. The towers leaned in overhead the way they did this far down.

The bruise in the sky was the bruise. A fourth VTOL crossed it going northeast — Arcturus board-floor late-shift letting out, by the timing, secondary commute to the unofficial late-night dining option three blocks south of the corporation district. Kyle had been there once in 2222 on a job and the food had been bad. The dining option's investor materials had not mentioned this. The dining option had nevertheless raised a Series C in 2224.

He laughed. Not the laugh the action movies he had never watched had taught the audience to expect. A single tight exhalation. The joke was that he had walked into a room of six men who would have killed an ordinary person for trying it, and he had walked out, and he was refusing free noodles from a woman whose entire life he had just rearranged, and he was doing it because honor was a discipline and the discipline did not bend for noodles, and any reasonable observer would have concluded he had lost his mind. He had not lost his mind. He was just the exception to the rule. The rule said: a man performing samurai discipline in 2226 will be killed for it inside a year. The rule was correct about almost everybody. It was not correct about Kyle, because Kyle was very good at the discipline, and the city, for all its talk, had not yet built a counter for *very good at the discipline*. It had built counters for many things. The corporations had paid for most of them. They had not yet decided he was the kind of problem worth paying for, because the problem he posed did not yet show on the kind of dashboard a corporation looked at. He was going to die at some point, probably soon, probably because somebody in Geneva eventually looked at a different dashboard.

In the meantime the noodles had been the right temperature, the chip had stayed on the counter, the rain was warm at this tier, the bike was running clean, and the world was the world but it was, this evening, the world at a tempo he could ride.

He laughed once more, smaller, almost to himself, and rode home.

Part III — The Watcher

Somebody had been watching the loading-dock work.

The camera was on the second floor of the building across the alley, in a window boarded over for the last eleven years, a panel of the plywood replaced with a panel that looked like the rest but was not. The camera saw through it. The feed ran on a private channel that did not touch the Carrion Logistics LLC grid. Carrion did not know about the camera. Nobody on the dock had. Kyle had known the way you knew about a draft — by feel, with no source.

The watcher was a woman named Hira Volkova, forty-two, fifteen years in the work, drank tea because coffee made her hands shake and the hands had to stay still on the audio sliders, and kept a bowl of dried apricots on the desk that she did not like but that were quiet to eat. Her organization had access to ambient citywide infrastructure telemetry that did not officially exist because the infrastructure that did not officially exist had been built by a corporation whose mergers had buried the inventory three asset transfers deep. Hira's salary was paid through four shell companies routed through a Helix subsidiary whose only employee was a man in Singapore who had not been to the office in six years. Hira did not know who, ultimately, signed her check. Hira had been doing this work long enough to have stopped asking. The check cleared and the work was the work and the work was, on any given week, the kind of work that produced reports nobody she could name read.

She watched the walk back from the dock to the bike. She noted that the pace did not change, that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya at any point, that the breathing telemetry stayed at the rest cycle. She noted, in particular, the cut to the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam, which had not produced a flare or an arc or anything else her organization had been told to watch for, because there had been nothing to flare with — the blade had found a gap and the gap had not held — and she wrote this in the report her organization had paid for and preferred to be correct, because correct

reports lowered the risk premium and lower risk premiums got passed up the chain to people who appreciated lower risk premiums.

She noted one thing she did not write down.

On a microphone better than anyone on the dock had known was present, she caught Kyle muttering a phrase between the boss's wrist falling and the blade going back in the saya. Three syllables. Not in any language Kyle spoke. She ran it against eleven candidate corpora and got an eighty-one-percent match to a sub-variant of Tocharian B that had not been adequately preserved in any extant corpus and that the algorithm had had to triangulate against three partial inscriptions and a guess. The translation came back, approximately, as *we have him now*.

She did not put the Tocharian in the report. She filed it on the encrypted side of her personal log, on a directory she had not touched in three years, because she had been doing this work for fifteen years and had learned that the things you filed separately were the things that turned out, eventually, to be the answer. The answer was going to belong to the people who signed her check. Hira had decided, somewhere in her seventh year, that some of the answers were going to belong to her too.

The report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, the south-arm cell captain of the Lotus Syndicate. Hua would close the file and pass it to her gang lieutenant Mira along with a second file labelled *Bucktown — first interview — fourteen-piece*. The Tocharian was not in the report Hua read. The Tocharian would not surface for some time. The people who would, eventually, learn what the Tocharian had said were not the people who had paid for the watcher. The chain ran past them. The chain ran past most things.

Kyle rode home. The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were. He did not yet know that he had begun to be assembled into a shape that was no longer his own, by people whose names he would not learn in this book, on a clock the corporations kept that he would only ever see parts of. The clock was older than him. The clock would outlast him. The clock would outlast the corporations too, eventually, because every clock eventually outlasted the people winding it.

That was the work of years.

Tonight was the work of one night, and tonight the work was done.

Hira put another apricot in her mouth, chewed it without enthusiasm, and watched the bike's running light fade north into the rain.

The city continued.

The corporations continued.

The trail led upstream.